

MEAL MARATHON

DOWNTOWN LA FOOD TOUR

"I'm Sally from the Valley," screamed our Vietnamese-American host. Sally Tiongco was born and raised in Southern California. In 2009, she gave up her profession as a school teacher and set up Six Taste Food Tours, so she could introduce visitors as well as locals to the culinary treasures of her city (the work-life balance was a bonus). We met Sally in front of the Grand Central Market, immediately engulfed in her bubbly warmth. In the last few decades, valiant attempts have been made to revitalise Downtown LA. These are now bearing fruit. The beating heart of this transformation is the more-than-a-century-old Grand Central Market. With over 50 minority-owned food stalls, it was just the spot to kick off our food marathon. Our first stop was Sarita's Pupuseria, where we sampled pupusa, the national dish of El Salvador. A grilled, thick flatbread stuffed with kidney beans, it was served with curtido, a spicy, fermented cabbage slaw. Think of it as a paratha stuffed with rajma. Our next stop was Sticky Rice, a home of Thai comfort food, where we dug into Gai Yang, juicy pieces of grilled chicken served with raw papaya salad. Then it was time for a walk to Chef Fred Eric's Pi' LA, purveyor of LA-style pizza. To

Clockwise from left: Cosy al fresco seating at Ka'teen; Vegan donuts at Donut Friend in Downtown Los Angeles; and the Grand Central Market in LA, which is a warren of foodie treasures

the sound of retro music, we dug into square-shaped slices of gourmet pizza in flavours I'd not encountered before. Our next stop was the legendary Guisados, where a taco sampler awaited. We were pretty stuffed but this was not an opportunity to be passed up, so we loosened our belts and dug in. That's the moment I died and went to taco heaven, gorging on Chuleta en Chile Verde (diced pork chop), Bistek en Salsa Roja (flank steak) and Mole Poblano (shredded chicken breast). We just about recovered and made it to the last leg of the tour—the vegan Donut Friend, where we had a passion fruit donut (they even have one called Poppy-Gandhi). What is the Sixth Taste, you may ask. Well, you'll just have to take the tour to find out!

Apart from Downtown LA, their most popular tour, Six Taste also offers food tours of Santa Monica, Little Tokyo, Thai Town, Hollywood, etc.

www.sixtaste.com

Cost US$85 per person plus taxes and fees

